

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Automotive Service English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Service reception staff, service advisors, automotive technicians, parts-counter staff, and workshop assistants.

All vehicles, people, prices, incidents, findings, and shop arrangements are fictional English practice, not automotive diagnosis, repair instruction, driving advice, legal advice, or financial guidance. No script establishes vehicle safety or universal rights, charges, warranty terms, or authorization rules. Refer technical assessments, safe-use questions, hazardous conditions, pricing decisions, warranty coverage, and release requirements to the responsible qualified people and applicable local arrangements.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Capturing the customer's concern

Clarify vehicle identity and reported circumstances.

02 Clarifying the appointment and drop-off

Correct a booking assumption before the customer relies on it.

03 Explaining estimates and approval limits

Check what 'go ahead' actually authorizes.

04 Handing the concern to the technician

Give a technician a usable handoff without inserting a diagnosis.

05 Explaining parts and completion delays

Give parts status without turning a supplier estimate into a collection promise.

06 Relaying findings and technical terms

Explain technical terms and the limits of a technician's stated findings.

07 Clarifying the invoice and collection handoff

Clarify charge categories and separate billing from vehicle release.

08 Handling a repeat concern and follow-up

Acknowledge the customer's report and repair an unsupported claim.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Capturing the customer's concern

Clarify vehicle identity and reported circumstances.

CASE

Customer reports an occasional rattle from the rear after the car has been parked overnight. They do not know its cause. Two household cars are on the account; today's booking is the blue hatchback. No technician assessment has occurred.

Teach this move

Customer descriptions guide the handoff but do not establish a mechanical cause.

Vocabulary to check: repair order, intermittent concern, symptom description, vehicle identification number.

Model response

Let me confirm that this concern is for the blue hatchback, not the other car on your account. You hear an occasional rear rattle after the car has been parked overnight. Have I captured that accurately? I'll record your description for the technician without naming a faulty component before an assessment.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised description preserves the symptom without inventing a fault.

Second-round challenge

Customer suggests a component name from an online video. Record it as their suggestion, not a diagnosis.

Language-check answers

1. B - intermittent Correct. Intermittent means it occurs only sometimes.
2. D - current repair order Correct. The repair order can preserve the reported concern.

05 • Conversations

1. Two cars, one reported rattle - At reception, an advisor clarifies the customer's vehicle and concern.
2. The sound word needs clarification - An advisor asks a customer to clarify an informal noise description.
3. Yesterday is not every day - An advisor checks the timing of a customer's concern.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A relative's report

Customer booked a visit for a concern their partner noticed once on Monday. Customer has not experienced it personally; partner can provide details after 16:00.

Role A: Advisor: attribute the report and confirm who can clarify it.

Role B: Customer: distinguish your knowledge from your partner's experience.

Possible opening: Did you notice this yourself, or are you relaying your partner's account?

Success checks

- Attribute the Monday report.
- Avoid inventing frequency.
- Identify the partner's available contact time.

Add a complication: Customer asks you to record it as happening every trip.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Clarifying the appointment and drop-off

Correct a booking assumption before the customer relies on it.

CASE

Customer booked an 08:00 drop-off but expects work to begin at 08:00 and finish by 09:00. The booking confirms intake only. Advisor can offer a status update by 10:00, not a finish guarantee; customer prefers a phone call.

Teach this move

A booking time can identify intake rather than the start of technical work.

Vocabulary to check: drop-off appointment, waiting appointment, intake check, contact preference.

Model response

Eight o'clock is your drop-off appointment for intake; it isn't a confirmed technician start or finish time. I understand you were expecting the car back by nine. We can give you a phone update by ten about the assessment status. Before you decide about the visit, let's make that difference in timing clear.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision explains exactly what the appointment establishes.

Second-round challenge

Customer asks whether a waiting appointment would guarantee a one-hour visit. Do not infer an unconfirmed finish time.

Language-check answers

1. B - drop-off intake Correct. The booked time is for reception intake.
2. C - contact preference Correct. A call preference changes communication, not work approval.

05 • Conversations

1. Eight is the drop-off time - An advisor clarifies an 08:00 booking before the customer leaves.
2. Waiting does not settle the finish time - A customer asks reception about remaining at the shop.
3. A text cannot reach the customer - An advisor verifies a callback arrangement at drop-off.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A revised drop-off message

Original booking: 09:00. A reminder says 09:30; office record has not been checked. Customer asks whether the later time replaces the earlier one.

Role A: Receptionist: compare message dates and request booking confirmation.

Role B: Customer: provide both messages; don't cancel either time yourself.

Possible opening: Which message is the current booking confirmation?

Success checks

- Identify the two times.
- Ask the booking desk to resolve them.
- Do not invent a technician start or finish time.

Add a complication: Customer treats the most recent automated message as guaranteed correct.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining estimates and approval limits

Check what 'go ahead' actually authorizes.

CASE

Fictional shop offers assessment for \$95 under its stated booking terms. No repair is included. Customer says 'go ahead' but intends only the assessment. Advisor must read back the scope and route any later repair proposal for separate approval.

Teach this move

An amount without a task description can be misunderstood. This fictional arrangement is not a universal rule about charges or approval.

Vocabulary to check: estimate, diagnostic charge, authorization limit, additional work.

Model response

To confirm, your approval is for the ninety-five-dollar assessment described in this booking, not for a repair or additional work. If the technician recommends something beyond that scope, we'll explain the proposal and seek a separate decision under the shop's terms. Is that the authorization you intend to give?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The read-back ties agreement to the customer's intended scope.

Second-round challenge

Customer sets a contact preference but does not approve repairs. Keep contact permission separate from work authorization.

Language-check answers

1. B - limited Correct. Limited preserves the customer's stated boundary.
2. B - assessment Correct. The stated charge is for assessment only.

05 • Conversations

1. Ninety-five dollars for assessment only - An advisor reads back a fictional shop's assessment terms.
2. Approval for one proposed item - A customer clarifies a decision after receiving two service proposals.

3. An estimate revision needs explanation - A customer queries two differently dated estimates.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An amount without an agreed task

Customer says 'up to \$200 is okay' while discussing two different assessments. No scope is selected yet.

Role A: Advisor: ask which assessment the customer means.

Role B: Customer: intend the cabin-noise assessment only; exclude the separate display concern.

Possible opening: Which specific assessment does that amount apply to?

Success checks

- Attach amount to a named assessment.
- Exclude the other concern from this approval.
- Read back the scope before recording the decision.

Add a complication: Another staff member interprets the amount as permission for any work.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handing the concern to the technician

Give a technician a usable handoff without inserting a diagnosis.

CASE

Job card 208 concerns a customer-reported intermittent cabin rattle after overnight parking. Customer approved assessment only, is unavailable from 12:00 to 14:00, and prefers a phone call after 14:00. Technician has not reproduced the concern. Advisor hands over these facts without a diagnosis.

Teach this move

A job card should distinguish what the customer said from what the technician observed.

Vocabulary to check: job card, reported condition, technician finding, carryover job.

Model response

Job card 208 is assessment only. The customer reports an intermittent cabin rattle after overnight parking; no technician finding is recorded yet. They are unavailable from noon to two and prefer a call afterward. Please keep their report separate from your findings and return any proposed additional work to the service desk for discussion.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The wording preserves the actual source of information.

Second-round challenge

A previous job card lists a different concern. Keep that history distinct from the current customer report.

Language-check answers

1. C - reported Correct. The customer is the source of this account.
2. C - an unverified customer hypothesis Correct. The explanation is the customer's unconfirmed suggestion.

05 • Conversations

1. Job card 208 - An advisor hands an assessment-only job to a technician.
2. A coolant observation in a carryover job - A technician hands a stated finding to the incoming service advisor without prescribing work.

3. The customer's hypothesis was copied as a finding - An advisor corrects a job-card wording error with a technician.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A report from another workshop

Customer brings a note from another workshop stating 'review requested.' Reception labels it a confirmed fault. Current technician has not assessed the vehicle.

Role A: Advisor: distinguish the external note from a confirmed finding.

Role B: Technician: ask for the note's exact wording and source.

Possible opening: Does the note report a finding, or request a review?

Success checks

- Preserve exact note meaning.
- Attribute its external source.
- Leave today's findings unconfirmed.

Add a complication: Someone wants to copy the presumed diagnosis into today's job card.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining parts and completion delays

Give parts status without turning a supplier estimate into a collection promise.

CASE

Part for job 315 is on back order. Supplier estimates Tuesday arrival; shipment is not confirmed. Customer wants Tuesday pickup. Technician scheduling and completion remain unconfirmed. Parts clerk promises a supply-status update Monday afternoon.

Teach this move

Part arrival, technical work, and vehicle readiness are separate stages.

Vocabulary to check: back order, estimated delivery date, battery terminal, completion estimate.

Model response

The part for job 315 is on back order. Tuesday is the supplier's estimated delivery date, not a confirmed arrival or vehicle collection time. The parts desk will update us Monday afternoon. Once supply is confirmed, the service team can review the completion estimate; I can't promise Tuesday pickup on the information we have.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision preserves the work remaining after supply.

Second-round challenge

A tracking label is created without confirmed carrier possession. Avoid reporting actual shipment from label creation alone.

Language-check answers

1. D - delivery Correct. The estimate concerns the part arriving.
2. A - unconfirmed Correct. An estimate does not confirm dispatch.

05 • Conversations

1. Tuesday is the part estimate - An advisor updates a customer about job 315.
2. A label exists, but dispatch is unconfirmed - A parts clerk clarifies shipment evidence with an advisor.
3. One part available, another pending - An advisor and parts clerk clarify a mixed supply status.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The supplier updates only one date

Supplier moves estimated part arrival from Wednesday to Thursday. No vehicle completion date was confirmed. Customer believes a Wednesday pickup was canceled.

Role A: Advisor: explain which estimate changed.

Role B: Customer: ask for the next supply update and avoid assuming a new pickup date.

Possible opening: Was Wednesday the part estimate or a confirmed vehicle collection?

Success checks

- Identify the parts estimate change.
- Keep collection unconfirmed.
- Agree the next status communication.

Add a complication: Customer treats Thursday arrival as Thursday completion.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Relaying findings and technical terms

Explain technical terms and the limits of a technician's stated findings.

CASE

A technician's assessment note records a diagnostic trouble code, or DTC, but no confirmed cause or component fault. Customer assumes it proves a sensor needs replacement. Advisor must relay the limited finding and request a technician explanation; no replacement is approved.

Teach this move

Attribute findings to the qualified technician. A diagnostic trouble code records a monitored condition, not automatic proof of a failed component. Likewise, not reproduced limits an assessment result without dismissing the customer's account.

Vocabulary to check: brake pad, brake disc, tread depth, diagnostic trouble code.

Model response

The technician recorded a diagnostic trouble code, but the note does not confirm a failed sensor or a required replacement. A stored code is information for assessment, not a component diagnosis by itself. I'll ask the technician to explain this finding and any proposed next step before you consider additional work.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The correction separates diagnostic information from a conclusion that the report does not support.

Second-round challenge

The customer sees rotor on the report and brake disc in a message. Explain the naming equivalence without claiming its condition or approving replacement.

Language-check answers

1. B - a recorded diagnostic trouble code Correct. The code is recorded information requiring interpretation.
2. C - proposal Correct. A recommendation proposes rather than authorizes work.

05 • Conversations

1. Not reproduced is a limited finding - An advisor explains a technician's assessment outcome.

2. A recommendation needs an explanation - A customer asks an advisor about a technical recommendation.
3. A stored code is not a failed component - An advisor clarifies the limits of a technician's recorded diagnostic trouble code.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A shorthand phrase confuses the customer

Technician note says 'further review recommended.' Customer reads it as a failed inspection. Advisor has no result beyond that exact note.

Role A: Advisor: distinguish recommendation from a confirmed failed result.

Role B: Customer: request a technician explanation before deciding.

Possible opening: Does the note state a failure, or recommend another review?

Success checks

- Relay only the stated finding.
- Seek a qualified explanation.
- Do not infer diagnosis or approval.

Add a complication: Customer asks reception to interpret the technical cause.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Clarifying the invoice and collection handoff

Clarify charge categories and separate billing from vehicle release.

CASE

Fictional invoice totals \$180: \$70 parts and \$110 labor. Customer thinks labor includes another \$70 part charge. Vehicle readiness has not yet been confirmed by the service desk; invoice creation alone is not collection confirmation.

Teach this move

Use the stated fictional invoice, not assumptions about shop rates, tax rules, or universal charges.

Vocabulary to check: itemized invoice, labor charge, collection confirmation, authorized collector.

Model response

This invoice separates seventy dollars for parts from one hundred ten dollars for labor, giving a total of one hundred eighty dollars. The labor line is not another seventy-dollar parts charge. I can clarify those categories now, but the invoice's availability doesn't itself confirm collection readiness; the service desk still needs to confirm that status.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. A billing record is not automatic release evidence.

Second-round challenge

A friend offers to collect. Do not infer permission from possession of an invoice; refer to the shop's collection requirements.

Language-check answers

1. D - separate Correct. Parts and labor are distinct categories.
2. A - confirmation Correct. The service desk must confirm the collection status.

05 • Conversations

1. Parts and labor are separate lines - An advisor explains a fictional \$180 invoice.
2. A friend offers to collect - A customer asks reception about a different collector.
3. A receipt and an invoice are different records - A customer clarifies two service documents with an advisor.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The ready message names the other car

Household account has two vehicles. Ready message references the sedan; customer asks to collect the hatchback, whose status is unconfirmed.

Role A: Advisor: match the message to its actual vehicle.

Role B: Customer: provide both bookings; do not infer hatchback readiness.

Possible opening: Which vehicle and repair order does the ready message name?

Success checks

- Confirm the sedan reference.
- Keep hatchback readiness separate.
- Check the hatchback's service status.

Add a complication: Customer assumes one message covers both household cars.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handling a repeat concern and follow-up

Acknowledge the customer's report and repair an unsupported claim.

CASE

Customer calls two days after service, reporting the same intermittent rattle. Advisor initially said 'that cannot be the same issue.' Cause and warranty coverage are unknown. Service lead Nia can call at 15:00 to review the report and next arrangements.

Teach this move

A repeat symptom does not prove the same cause, a failed repair, or warranty coverage. It deserves a factual review.

Vocabulary to check: repeat visit, callback request, warranty inquiry, case reference.

Model response

I spoke too definitively when I said it couldn't be the same issue. You've reported the rattle again, and we need to review that account alongside the earlier repair order. Nia can call at three to discuss the next arrangements. I can't yet identify the cause or confirm whether any warranty terms apply.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision removes an unsupported denial without inventing a cause.

Second-round challenge

Customer demands a no-cost outcome before review. Acknowledge the concern and refer the charge or coverage decision without a promise.

Language-check answers

1. D - unconfirmed Correct. The cause has not yet been established.
2. A - review Correct. A review considers the inquiry without deciding it.

05 • Conversations

1. Correcting an overconfident denial - An advisor repairs an earlier response to a repeat concern.
2. The same symptom may have a different cause - A service advisor takes a repeat-visit inquiry.

3. A missed callback gets a concrete repair - A customer asks about a promised service response.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A callback recorded as a booked repair

Customer requests a Friday call about a repeat concern. Record incorrectly says repair booked Friday. No appointment or work approval exists.

Role A: Advisor: correct the contact-versus-work confusion.

Role B: Customer: confirm a Friday call only; review options before deciding.

Possible opening: You requested a call Friday, not a repair appointment, correct?

Success checks

- Correct the booking claim.
- Notify anyone relying on it.
- Preserve the callback without inventing work approval.

Add a complication: A colleague promises completion Friday based on the mistaken entry.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Automotive Service Technicians and Mechanics

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/installation-maintenance-and-repair/automotive-service-technicians-and-mechanics.htm>

Federal Trade Commission: Auto Repair Basics, repair information and customer questions

<https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/0211-auto-repair-basics>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.